

some specific way using a computer. It's these kinds of users that Linux has failed to entice, until now. Accomplishing things for the average Joe is not the most intuitive of tasks in most Linux distros. Which is why Joe thinks 'you get what you pay for', and happily goes out and buys (or doesn't, we know you Joes very well) a Mac or a copy of Windows. But the gist of the matter is that Joe was not impressed by what he saw. That should be changing right about now, with teams dedicating considerable resources to achieving in aesthetics the level that they are at in the underlying tech. Some of the most notable examples include "elementary OS" – the latest rave among the hacker crowd, or even the redesigned Ubuntu which now runs on its own front-end of the Unity interface. These changes have not gone down well with those who already knew what they were doing when they entered the command line, but the general public perception has most certainly improved for these decisions.

Catering to an audience that is so used to hand-holding that they don't know anything else is something of an uncharted territory for most of these 'open' platforms. But the forays made in this regard by the frontrunners such as Ubuntu, Mint, openSUSE and their ilk have been admirable. Another great thing to see is that the community of developers at large are starting to come to terms with the fact that users don't want a hatful of features that they can tune to their heart's delight – they want something that just works. Something that when plugged in, does what needs to be done and gets out of your way in doing so. You cannot fault the earlier versions of distros for not taking this approach – they've only just started going after mass-market popularity. The days when it mattered what kernel version you're using underneath are pretty much over. Sure, you can go into the settings menu and see the kernel version, but how many users really care? And the thing is, users generally shouldn't care. They really shouldn't care what operating system they're running, they should care about the work they get done. The operating system should not only be invisible, but pretty much irrelevant to the average user.

Entertainment

Ah, yes, a part of the small set of things that Linux still does best among all the other OS choices out there. Owing to the presence of bundles of dedicated HTPC software that are freely available for Linux, it is possible for you to transform your machine into a fully featured, powerful beast of an entertainment entity for free. The only problem is that most of you don't